

AYE
FIT HUB

• CRF • DAY 3

Core Anatomy

Why Your Core Is More Than Abs

Day 3 of 30 | Core & Flexibility

Awet G. Nway

Mechanical Engineer & Fitness Coach

- Core muscle anatomy & function
- 7 essential core exercises
- Breathing & bracing technique

01 | What Is the Core — Really?

Most people think "core" means six-pack abs. That is one small piece of a large system. Your core is a cylinder of 35+ muscles spanning from your diaphragm at the top to the pelvic floor at the bottom, with the lumbar spine at the center. Every movement your body makes — lifting, running, sitting, breathing — is either generated or stabilised by the core.

A weak core does not just look flat. It causes lower back pain, poor posture, reduced athletic performance, and injury risk in every other exercise. Strengthening it is foundational — which is exactly why it appears on Day 3 before any heavy training begins.

02 | Core Muscle Groups & Their Function

Muscle Group	Location	Primary Function
Rectus Abdominis	Front of abdomen (the "6-pack")	Spinal flexion (crunching forward). Least important for stability.
Transverse Abdominis	Deepest abdominal layer	Natural "weight belt" — compresses abdomen, protects spine during lifts.
Internal & External Obliques	Sides of abdomen	Rotation, lateral flexion, anti-rotation stability.
Multifidus	Along the spine (back)	Spinal stabilisation segment by segment. Critical for back health.
Erector Spinae	Runs length of the back	Keeps spine upright, extends the back.
Quadratus Lumborum	Deep lower back (QL)	Lateral stability, hip elevation. Often the source of lower back pain.
Diaphragm	Top of the core cylinder	Breathing and intra-abdominal pressure (IAP) — key for bracing.
Pelvic Floor	Base of the core cylinder	Supports organs, coordinates with diaphragm during exertion.
Glutes (Medius/Max)	Hips and buttocks	Hip stability and power transfer — often called the "foundation" of the core.

■ INFO — The Most Underrated Core Muscle

The Transverse Abdominis (TVA) is the muscle elite athletes train most deliberately. It wraps around your spine like a corset. When braced correctly, it protects your lumbar spine under heavy load. Planks and dead bugs train it far better than crunches.

03 | Bracing vs Sucking In — The Key Technique

There are two ways people brace their core — and one is wrong.

Technique	What It Looks Like	Effect
Sucking in	Pull belly button toward spine	Deactivates TVA. Reduces stability. WRONG for training.
Bracing	Expand 360° — push belly out AND sides AND back	Activates full core cylinder. Creates maximum spinal stability. CORRECT

■■ DRILL — Practice This Now

Stand up. Take a breath in. Now brace as if someone is about to punch you in the stomach — expand your belly out, sides wide, and feel your lower back push slightly outward. Hold 5 seconds. That is proper bracing. Use this in every exercise from now on.

04 | Day 3 Workout — Core Foundation Circuit

Focus: Quality over quantity. Brace properly on every rep. **Equipment:** Mat or soft surface. **Time:** 20–25 minutes.

WARM-UP (3 min)

Exercise	Sets	Duration	Notes
Cat-Cow stretch	1	60 sec	5 sec per position, slow breath
Knee-to-chest pulls	1	30 sec/leg	Lying on back, gentle pull
Bird-Dog (slow)	1	60 sec	5 sec hold each side

MAIN CIRCUIT — 3 Rounds | Rest 45 sec between rounds

#	Exercise	Sets	Reps / Time	Your Reps
1	Dead Bug	3	5 reps/side	___
2	Plank (forearm)	3	20–40 sec	___
3	Side Plank	3	15–25 sec/side	___
4	Glute Bridge	3	12 reps	___
5	Bird-Dog	3	8 reps/side	___
6	Hollow Body Hold	3	10–20 sec	___
7	Superman Hold	3	8 reps, 3 sec hold	___

■ INFO — The Dead Bug Is King

The Dead Bug is the single best core exercise for beginners. It trains the TVA, forces proper breathing, and protects the lower back — all at once. Go slow: 5 seconds to extend, 5 seconds to return. If your lower back arches, stop and reset.

05 | Core Training Quick Reference

Rule	Guideline
Train core daily?	No. 3–4 times per week is optimal. Core needs recovery like any muscle.
Best exercises	Plank, Dead Bug, Bird-Dog, Hollow Hold — anti-movement is key.
Worst exercises	High-rep crunches and sit-ups. They train rectus abdominis only and stress the spine.
Breathing during lifts	Inhale to brace → exert on exhale. Never hold breath for more than 1–2 reps.
Lower back pain	Often caused by weak glutes + weak TVA. Day 3 exercises directly address this.
Core & aesthetics	Visible abs come from low body fat (nutrition), not from crunches. Train core for function first.

06 | Day 3 Self-Check Question

Complete this honestly before moving to Day 4.

"During the plank and dead bug, did you feel your core working — or were you compensating with your neck, shoulders, or lower back? Which muscle group felt weakest and what will you focus on next session?"

Your answer:

Next up — Day 4:
Home Workout Setup — No Equipment, No Excuses

Community & support:
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